

RAM drives makes these drives a very useful tool for those who require video capture and video editing. DVD-RAMs are also especially good for backups, since you can make incremental backups. (Incremental backups are those that only incorporate changes since the last backup.)

CD burning

Almost all the drives supported writing to CD-R at 48x. The Asus supported only 40x for CD-R, but strangely, it supported 32x for CD-RW, which is the UltraSpeed standard. Some vendors adver-

tise their products as supporting the UltraSpeed standard; the HighSpeed standard is 24x for CD-RW.

LightScribe

The LightScribe technology has been around for quite a few months, but drives supporting this standard are just appearing in the Indian market. The Lite-On SHW-16H5S and the BenQ DW1625 were the only drives that supported LightScribe. As you might know, LightScribe is a technology that allows you to etch CD or DVD labels on compatible media using the drive's laser. This is an exciting technology, and with plummeting drive and media prices, it's bound to soon catch people's fancy.

Form Factors

Most of the drives featured the half-height form factor. Half-height drives have a much lower depth than do traditional drives, and can fit in almost any cabinet, leaving space for better air ventilation. Such drives also tend to interfere less with other PC components such as the motherboard, memory, and cables.



Plextor PX-716A

So What In The World Is LightScribe?

After burning a CD or a DVD, you mark it in order to identify its contents. Traditionally, this is done by marking the disc's label surface with a marker pen—writing out the title of the disc or listing its contents. This can damage the disc if too much pressure is applied while writing. And then there is the messy possibility of ink spilling. Also, the disc could fall (and thereby get scratched) while you're writing on it. And finally, handwritten notes on a disc don't look pretty!

An alternative way of marking a disc's contents is to print the CD/DVD face label on readily-available sticky labels and then stick them on the disc face. This has to be done with caution because if the label is not stuck properly, it might dislodge while it's in the drive and the disc is spinning, thereby damaging the drive.

All this is changing with the introduction of LightScribe. Invented by Hewlett-Packard Development Company, L.P., LightScribe is a direct disc labelling technology, an exciting new way of disc labelling that enables you to <burn> CD and DVD labels by simply flipping a disc and putting them back in the drive!

LightScribe drives can burn text and graphics onto the surface of a LightScribe disc using the drive's laser. LightScribe discs are coated with a special reactive dye that changes chemically when a 780 nm infrared laser

strikes the disc's label side, creating <etched> text and images.

To be LightScribe-capable, you need to have a LightScribe drive, LightScribe compatible media, and a LightScribe capable CD/DVD burning software. Some LightScribe capable CD/DVD burning software such as Nero can import digital photos, images or text and burn it as Title, Content, or Full (meaning both Title and Content)—either in a circular or a straight way and this determines the amount of radial space that it will occupy. While you cannot rewrite or erase a LightScribe label, you can add more content in the available un-reacted space.

The chemical reaction of the coating material with the laser beam is non-toxic and odourless, and the label produced is supposed to last for nine months under indoor lighting without fading. At present, you can only print LightScribe labels in greyscale, but in the coming years, you can expect LightScribe drives that print full-colour labels.

While the technology is currently limited to PC CD and DVD drives, HP plans to make this technology a part of consumer electronics by introducing it in home entertainment products such as stereo-component CD recording decks and set-top DVD recorders. So let your creativity flow, and add a personal touch to your discs. Burn, flip, burn!

WISDOM OF THE ORIENT SERIES #25

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"Wise men subscribe
when the time is ripe.
The unwise keep
waiting for a better offer
that may never come"

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